

UNHCR AFGHANISTAN

BORDER MONITORING

JANUARY- APRIL 2026



UNHCR Supports Registered Refugees Returning from Iran through Voluntary Repatriation Programme at Encashment Centre in Herat province
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44,335
Inflow and Outflow
Monitoring Interviews



31,327
71%



13,008
29%

BACKGROUND AND METHODOLOGY

- In line with UNHCR's protection monitoring objectives, UNHCR maintains a strong presence through border monitoring partners at official and unofficial crossing points connecting Afghanistan with Iran, Pakistan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, and Turkmenistan. The monitoring exercise is protection-focused and aims to assess the triggers, intentions, and motives behind Afghan cross-border movements, including protection needs, movement trends, and related protection risks and human rights concerns.
- UNHCR conducts inflow and outflow monitoring interviews at individual and household levels across ten official crossing points, while Key Informant Interviews (KIs) are conducted at around 70 unofficial crossing points.
- Outflow monitoring at official borders covers passport holders, whereas inflow monitoring covers Afghan returnees and deportees upon arrival, regardless of documentation status. At unofficial borders, KIs include transport drivers, nearby business owners, community elders, and local health providers.
- Respondents are selected using a systematic sampling approach, based on a fixed skipping interval determined by the average number of arrivals/departures during the previous week.
- During the first quarter of 2026, UNHCR border monitoring partners conducted 44,335 interviews, including 455 KIs, at 9 official and 65 unofficial crossing points.
- Among respondents, 65 percent were aged 18–34, 32 percent were aged 35–59, 1 percent were aged 12–17, and 2 percent were aged 60 and above – see charts #1 and #2.
- The lower proportion of female respondents reflects the profiles of individuals crossing the borders and operational constraints (see page 2). UNHCR and partners have continued efforts to increase female participation, including recruiting female staff and providing separate interview spaces. These measures enabled the inclusion of 13,008 female respondents, representing 29 percent of 44,335 respondents during January to April 2026. While slightly below the 32 percent female sample size recorded in 2025, reaching 29 percent within the first four months of 2026 indicates positive progress, with continued mitigation efforts expected to further improve female participation in the coming months.

Chart # 1: Number of interviews by official entry point

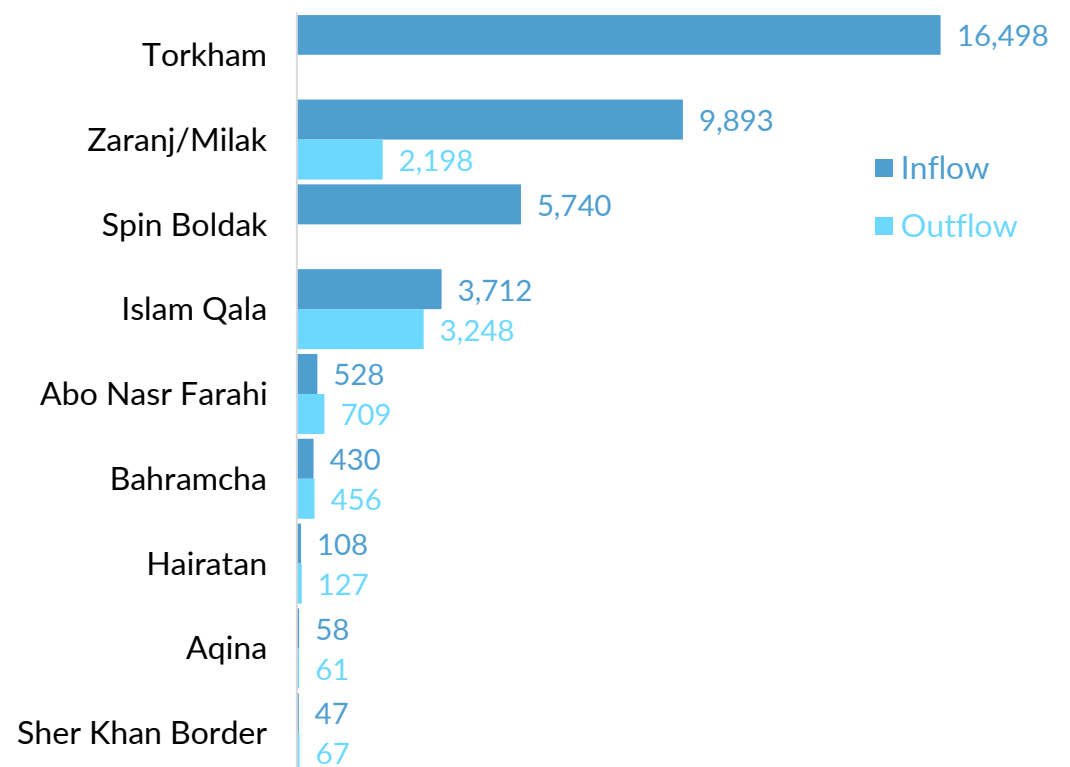
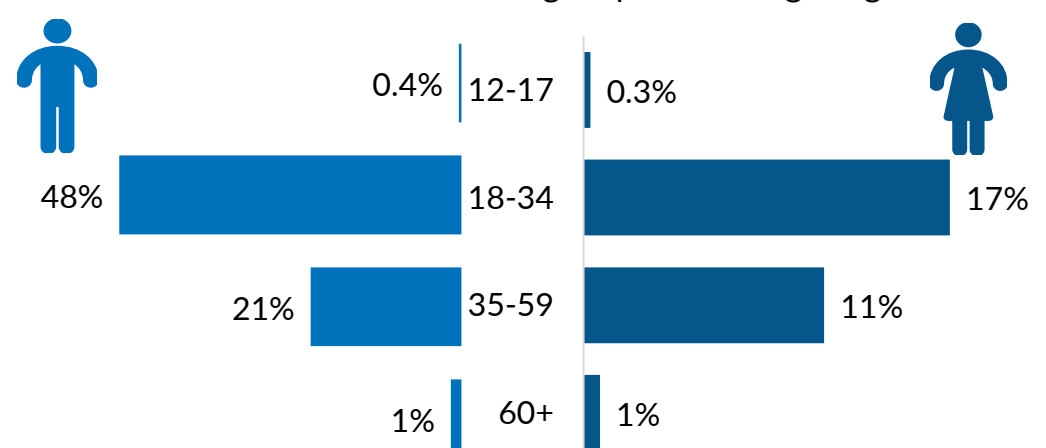


Chart #2: In and outflow monitoring respondents age & gender



Inflow Monitoring Findings

1 January – 30 April 2026



37,014

Interviews



23,438

families



24,037

65%



12,977

35%

SUMMARY FINDINGS

- 37,014 Afghans – 24,037 male (65 percent) and 12,977 female (35 percent) – were interviewed at nine official crossing points during the first quarter of 2026 upon arrival in Afghanistan (see chart # 3). This includes 23,438 families and 13,576 single individuals. Some 26,311 interviews were conducted with returnees and 11,028 with deportees. Afghans who returned/ were deported from Pakistan in 2026 were mainly families with women, children making up 80 percent of the returns (50 percent women and girls). UNHCR continues to receive inquiries from women, seeking support to access their rights and essential services, including education, healthcare, and livelihood opportunities, while also raising concerns about the protection environment for women in the country. These cases involve allegation about forced marriages, freedom of movement, denial of job opportunities, and other forms of gender discrimination. Women have also reported that their livelihoods have been detrimentally impacted by DfA policies.
- 64 percent of the respondents were 18-34 years old, while 33 percent were 35-59 years old, only one percent minors (12-17 years old), and two percent were older persons (60 and above), (chart # 4).
- A majority (79 percent) of respondents from Iran were undocumented, 12 percent were head-counted slip, one percent Amayesh cards and VRF and 7 percent passport holders. In contrast, 57 percent of respondents from Pakistan were PoR, 13 percent ACC, 6 percent VRF holders, one percent holders of UNHCR's slip or asylum certificate while 23 percent were undocumented.
- Findings from 2026 interviews with returnees and deportees indicate that Afghans continue to rely heavily on unofficial crossing points, particularly when travelling to Iran. In 2026, 86 percent of returnees and deportees, including women and children, reported entering Iran through unofficial routes, a trend that remains consistent with 2025 (85 percent) and 2024 (89 percent). This persistent reliance on informal crossings reflects ongoing barriers to regular movement, including limited access to visa, fear of arrest or refoulement, and protection concerns, especially for women and girls as well as persons with heightened protection risks pushing them toward riskier pathways. In contrast, movements to Pakistan show a different pattern. In 2026, 73 percent of respondents reported using official border crossings, a proportion similar to 2025 and 2024, but notably lower than in 2023, when 92 percent crossed through official points. This gradual decline suggests increasing movement constraints, including tightened border controls and documentation requirements, which may be reducing access to formal entry points overtime (chart # 9, page 5).
- Data from the first quarter of 2026 points to shifting patterns in first-time cross-border movements among Afghan returnees and deportees using official crossings. While the proportion of first-time travelers to Iran declined (39 per cent, down from 61 per cent in 2025), movements to Pakistan show a marked increase in first-time departures (72 per cent, up from 39 per cent), (chart #5 page 5). This divergence suggests evolving mobility dynamics influenced by stricter border enforcement and entry regulations in both Iran and Pakistan, including tightened documentation requirements, increased controls at official crossing points, and restrictions on regular entry pathways for Afghans. It also reflects limited access to safe and orderly crossing options, alongside shifting destination preferences driven by changing admission conditions and enforcement practices in Iran and Pakistan. Overall, the rise in first-time movements to Pakistan, alongside decreased initial movements to Iran, indicates a reorientation of displacement pathways and coping strategies, with new population groups increasingly engaging in cross-border mobility.
- From a protection perspective, these trends point to increasingly complex and interlinked drivers of displacement. The decline in first-time movements to Iran, alongside a sharp rise in first-time movements to Pakistan, likely reflects shifting access dynamics, tightened border controls, and evolving coping strategies. At the same time, the data suggests that individuals and families who may previously be preferred to remain in Afghanistan are now resorting to cross-border movement to seek better protection and access to rights and service. This shift is influenced by a combination of challenges affecting access to basic rights and services, including those faced by women, girls, and individuals with specific needs, as well as broader socio-economic pressures such as constrained livelihood opportunities and reduced access to essential services. The growth in first-time movements to Pakistan further indicates that cross-border mobility is expanding beyond established networks and repeat movers, increasingly involving populations seeking immediate safety, protection, and access to essential services. Overall, these dynamics underscore that such movements are not solely economically driven but are closely linked to underlying protection concerns, reinforcing the continued importance of access to international protection and safe, regular pathways.
- 37 percent of respondents returning from Iran and 84 percent of those returning from Pakistan stated that they had no information about the safety and protection risks of irregular movements to Iran and Pakistan and onward movement (chart #7, page 5). Those using these unofficial crossing points reported severe protection risks, including lack of food, water, healthcare, shelter, harassment, shootings by border guards, extortion, robbery, and exploitation. Vulnerability to human trafficking and abuse by smugglers remains high, as people risk their lives seeking safety or income in Iran or Pakistan (see chart # 6 page 5).
- 61 percent of respondents who returned/deported from Iran to Afghanistan and 17 percent of the respondents returned/deported from Pakistan cited that they are experiencing stress which affects their day-to-day life. The causes of stress includes economic hardship, loss of assets, uncertainty about the future, food insecurity, health problems, community tension, risk of arrest and detention, family separation and no education for females in Afghanistan, (chart # 8 &10, page 5).

Chart #3: Number of interviews by official entry point

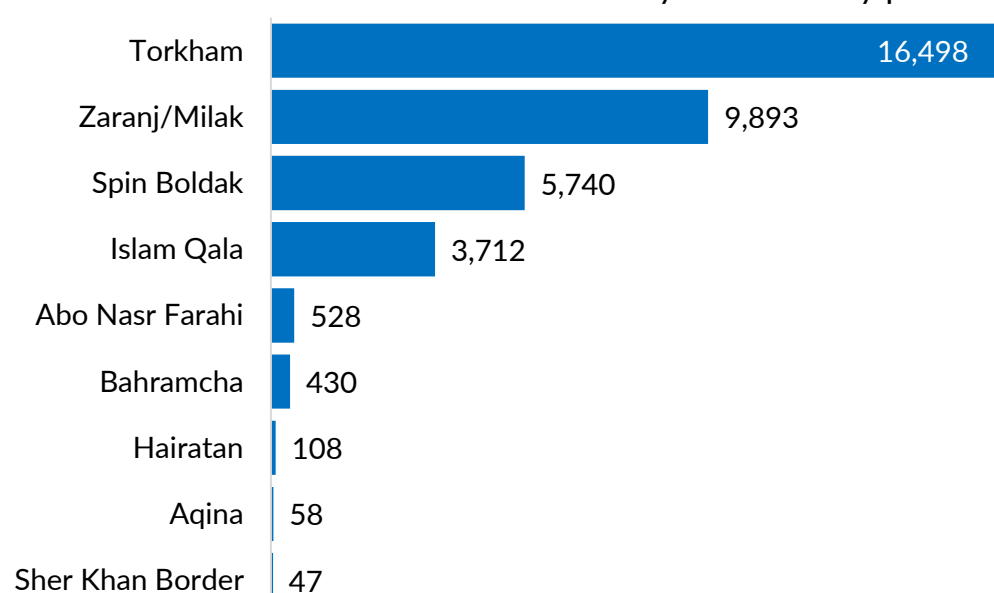
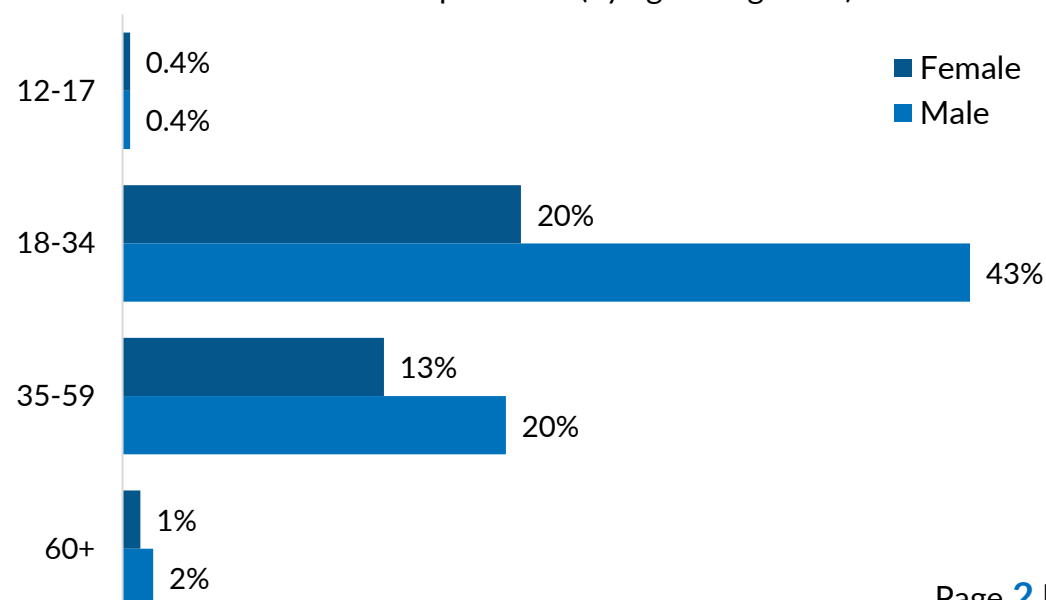


Chart #4: Respondents (by age and gender)



Inflow Monitoring Findings

1 January – 30 April 2026

Return Protection Response



Step 1 – Initial Screening

- Trained UNHCR protection staff proactively and sensitively identified refugee returnees and deportees, including individuals with heightened protection risks (e.g. former government officials, human rights defenders, journalists). Persons at risk were referred to UNHCR’s return processing centers in Reception Centers (RCs)/Herat EC for return assistance, in full respect of confidentiality, informed consent, and the do-no-harm principle.

Step 2 - Intake/eligibility assessment at EC/RC

- Gender-balanced teams conducted eligibility screening to verify return documentation and identify persons with specific needs using AGD principles.
- Dissemination of accurate information on services, procedures, and rights/entitlements.

Note: UNHCR previously managed four Encashment Centers in Kabul, Kandahar, Herat, and Jalalabad, through which returnees and deportees accessed protection services, including cash-based assistance.

- In May 2025, the Herat EC was relocated to the Islam Qala inter-agency Reception Center to ensure timely response to large-scale returns and deportations from Iran.*
- In November 2025, operations at Kabul, Jalalabad, and Kandahar ECs were suspended following restrictions on female staff, and activities were relocated to the Omari and Takhtapol Reception Centers. In response to increased returns via the Bahramcha crossing point in Helmand province, UNHCR established a return processing facility in Lashkargah, Helmand province.*
- In December 2025, due to the ban on female staff at Islam Qala RC, return assistance operations were shifted back to Herat EC.*

Step 3 – Registration

- Registration using the Biometric Identity Management System (BIMS), including the issuance of QR-coded tokens and collection of biodata through harmonized KoBo-based tools. These measures strengthened case integrity, prevented duplication and fraud, and were implemented in full compliance with UNHCR Data Protection Principles.

Step 4 - Protection desk

- UNHCR protection staff conducted confidential, survivor-centered interviews with women, men, girls, and boys presenting heightened protection risks, ensuring safe access to protection counseling and tailored referrals.

Step 5 - Provision of Assistance

- Provision of cash assistance through HesabPay cards: AFN 11,500 per household (regardless of family size), with an additional AFN 2,300 top-up for households headed by women and household member(s) with disabilities. The package is aligned with the Cash Working Group Minimum Expenditure Basket.

Returnee monitoring: Returnee monitoring is an inherent part of the protection monitoring carried out on arrival as well as for follow-up post return via phone-based surveys in return areas. These interlinked interviews aim to:

- ✓ Assesses key areas such as return patterns and protection concerns.
- ✓ Assessment of the voluntariness of return and the level of information returnees had to make a well-informed decision to return.
- ✓ Reintegration progress, access to documentation, housing, and essential services as well as returnees’ intentions.
- ✓ Highlighting gaps, including the impact of return assistance provided upon arrival and in return areas.

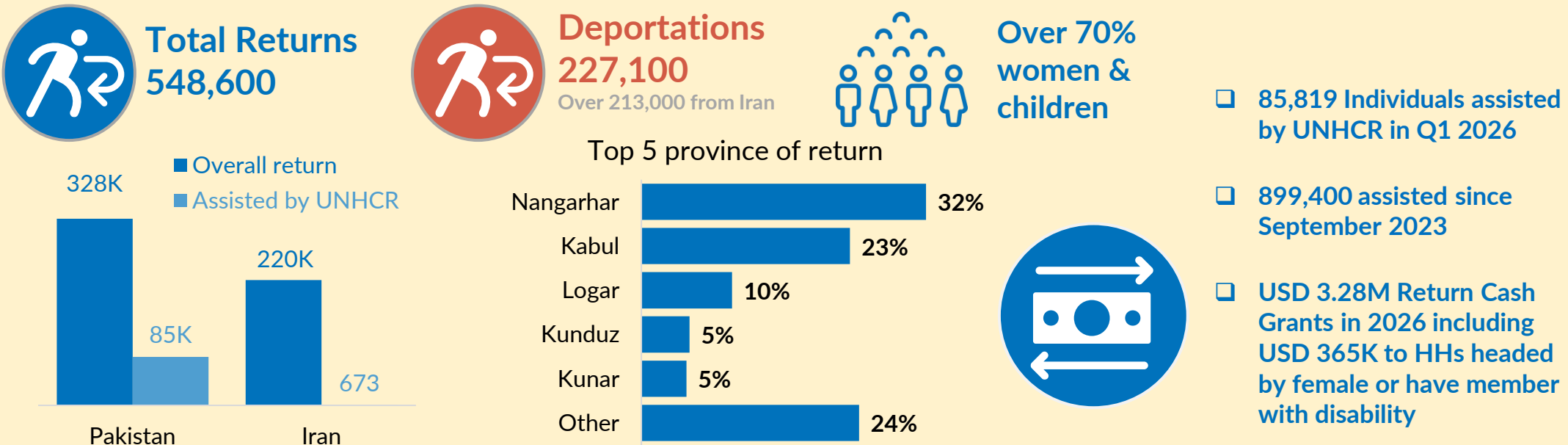
For further details regarding returnees' protection situation in return areas, please refer to UNHCR’s Post-Return Monitoring (PRM) Phone Survey, Third Round Results, including the [Executive Summary](#) and [Full Report](#), which provide comprehensive analysis of protection risks, living conditions, and reintegration challenges faced by Afghan returnees.



Thousands of Afghans return to their homeland amid a sharp increase in returns and deportations from Iran and Pakistan.
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Inflow Monitoring Findings - Return Trends

1 January – 30 April 2026



RETURN TRENDS AND PROTECTION IMPLICATIONS

- During the first quarter of 2026, Afghanistan continued to receive large number of returns, with some 548,600 Afghans returning or being deported from Iran and Pakistan, alongside smaller numbers returning from Tajikistan and India, bringing the total number of Afghan returns since 15 September 2023 to close to 6 million, representing 15 percent of Afghanistan estimated population. These movements largely driven by restrictive policies and deteriorating conditions in host countries, particularly Pakistan and Iran. Many returns occurred under adverse condition, involving abrupt departures and arduous journeys back to Afghanistan amid adverse conditions abroad.
- Iran:** Returns and deportations from Iran in the first quarter of 2026 remained relatively stable, averaging approximately 2,200 individuals per day, in line with December 2025 levels (2,450 daily). This indicates continued large-scale but predictable return dynamics, largely driven by sustained enforcement practices. Between 28 February and 30 April, approximately 115,000 Afghans returned or were deported from Iran, including during the Middle-East tensions involving Iran, the United States, and Israel. However, these developments did not significantly alter overall trends. Compared to the aftermath of the June to July 2025 escalation coinciding with the ongoing ‘regularization plan’, when returns peaked at over 40,000 individuals in a single day on 4 July 2025, current figures remain substantially lower, suggesting slower return patterns following earlier shocks (charts # 19 and 20, page 7).
- Pakistan:** In contrast, returns from Pakistan have been highly volatile and significantly elevated, with approximately 328,000 individuals returned or deported during the first quarter of 2026. Monthly figures fluctuated sharply, over 73,000 in January, rising to 87,300 in February, dropping to 7,700 in March, and surging to nearly 160,000 in April. The decline in March is largely attributable to the Ramadan and Eid festive period, which typically slows enforcement and cross-border activity. Notably, 156,600 individuals returned during this period were Proof of Registration (PoR) card holders, highlighting that individuals with recognized status are increasingly affected. This represents a significant increase compared to 131,000 returns in Q1 2025 and 79,600 during the same period in 2024 (charts # 17 and 18, page 7).
- From a protection perspective, these trends reflect a shrinking protection space for Afghans in both Iran and Pakistan, characterized by intensified enforcement measures including police raids, harassment, extortion, arrests, and deportations, and reduced access to legal stay. The scale and volatility of returns, particularly from Pakistan, raise concerns regarding forced/involuntary return, limited due process, and heightened protection risks upon return, including family separation and loss of documentation. The cancellation of PoR card validity and overall tight protection space underscores growing protection gaps and the erosion of protection safeguards. In Iran, large-scale protests in January 2026 as well as the escalation of the security situation in February and April have contributed to the volatility of return rates. Combined, these dynamics are likely to exacerbate vulnerabilities inside Afghanistan, strain absorption capacity, and contribute to cycles of onward and repeated displacement, as returnees continue to face violation of rights, protection risks and lack of access to basic services, food security, shelter and livelihoods.
- A total of 285 Afghans, including refugees and asylum seekers, were deported from Tajikistan in Q1 2026, nearly double the 143 recorded in the same period of 2025, amid increased enforcement targeting Afghan communities. Preliminary data shows a sharp escalation in May 2026, with over 700 deportations, well above previous monthly levels, reportedly involving arrests without due process and accounts of mistreatment during detention. These trends raise serious protection concerns regarding involuntary return and limited safeguards. UNHCR has engaged authorities, and further details will be provided in the next report.
- UNHCR provided protection assistance including cash grant to a total of 85,819 Afghan refugees and those in refuge-like situations who returned/were deported in 2026. This figure brings the total assistance provided to returnees by UNHCR since September 2023 to 899,400 individuals. The number of returnees assisted by UNHCR in 2026 represent significant increase compared to the same period in 2025 (14,147 individuals), underscoring the scale and intensity of this return surge.
- This unprecedented return trend has been driven by Pakistan’s Illegal Foreigners Repatriation Plan (IFRP), particularly Phase III from August 2025 targeting PoR card holders, and Iran’s regularization/return measures since mid-2025. Large-scale returns since September 2023 have placed significant strain on reception areas in Afghanistan, deepening protection gaps and limiting access to essential services. Women and girls - who represent over half of returnees - face heightened risks, including severe restrictions on education, employment, and freedom of movement. Individuals with heightened protection needs are returning to a fragile environment marked by ongoing human rights concerns, including risks of harassment, discrimination, and arbitrary arrest.

DRIVERS OF RETURN

- Pakistan:** Returns from Pakistan continue to be strongly linked to the phased implementation of the IFRP, which expanded in July 2025 to include PoR card holders. Compared to 2025, enforcement in 2026 reflects a further contraction of protection space, with returnees reporting on-going harassment, arrests, extortion, and forced evictions. Large-scale police operations, detention, and confiscation of documents have driven abrupt departures, often resulting in asset loss and family separation. These patterns indicate a shift from pressured to increasingly coercive returns, affecting Afghans regardless of status, particularly those with heightened protection risks (charts # 11, page 6).
- Iran:** Returns from Iran remain driven by a combination of enforcement measures and deteriorating living conditions. Following the 2025 regularization plan affecting up to two million Afghans, continued requirements to regularize status, coupled with discrimination, movement restrictions, and reduced livelihoods, have sustained return pressures into 2026. While conditions pressuring Afghans to return appear marginally less acute than June 2025, returnees still report harassment and barriers to services. Compared to 2025, returns remain largely distress-driven, linked to uncertainty, economic hardship, and constrained mobility (chart #12, page 6).
- Tajikistan:** Returns have risen as compared to 2025, with increased enforcement, arrests, and deportations without due process. Reports of document confiscation, mistreatment in detention, and family separation raise serious protection concerns, including risks for individuals with heightened risks.
- Across all three countries, returns in 2026 are increasingly shaped by shrinking protection space, intensified enforcement, and limited legal pathways. Compared to 2025, there is a clear shift toward more coercive/involuntary and less predictable return dynamics, with heightened risks of family separation. Combined with Afghanistan’s ongoing human rights and socio-economic crisis, these trends deepen vulnerabilities upon return and contribute to cyclical displacement, underscoring significant and ongoing international protection needs, particularly for women and girls as highlighted in [UNHCR’s Guidance Note on Afghanistan – Update II - September 2025](#).

Chart # 5: Movement frequency of passport holding respondents via official crossing points
(% of interviews per country)

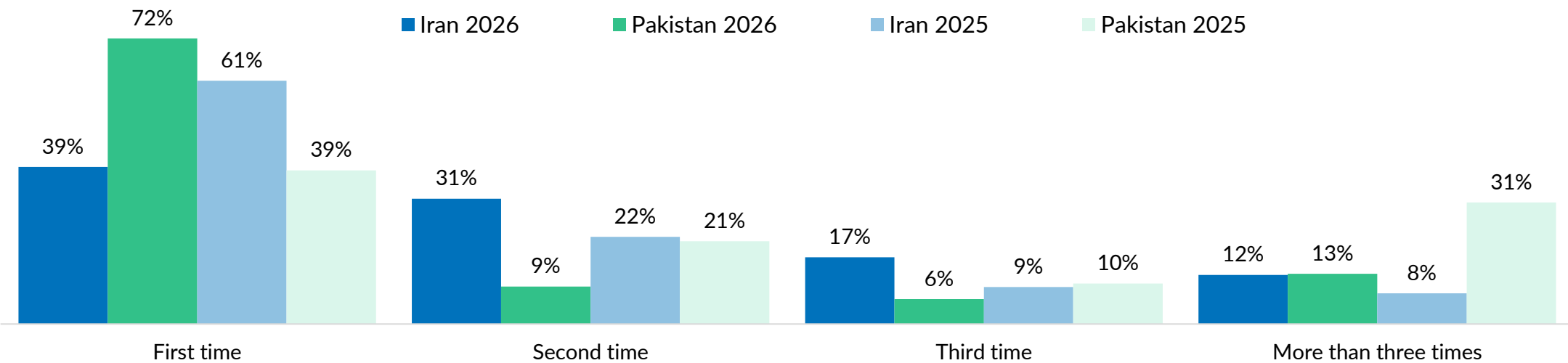


Chart # 6: Problems faced during the journey through unofficial crossing points

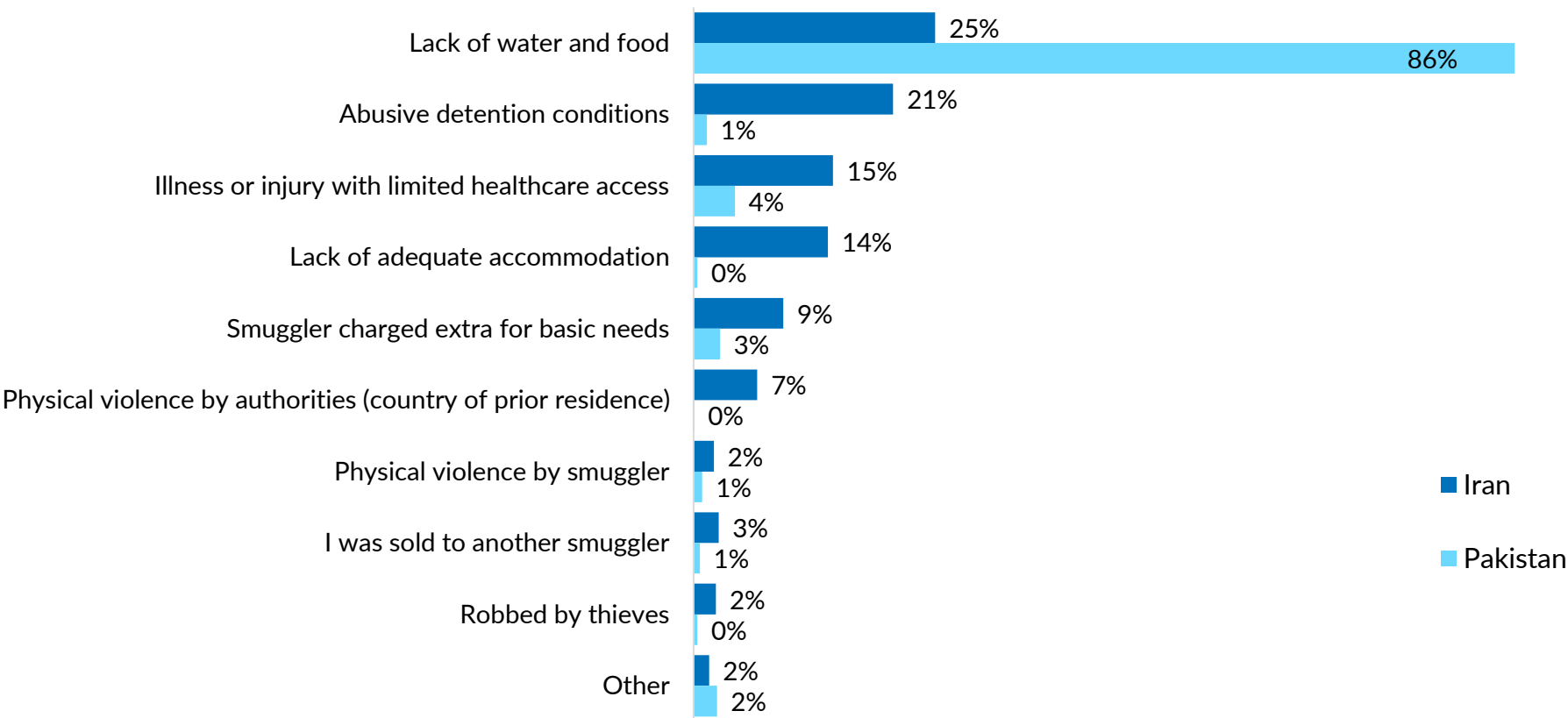


Chart # 7: Awareness of interviewed returnees/deportees about the potential protection risks of irregular movements

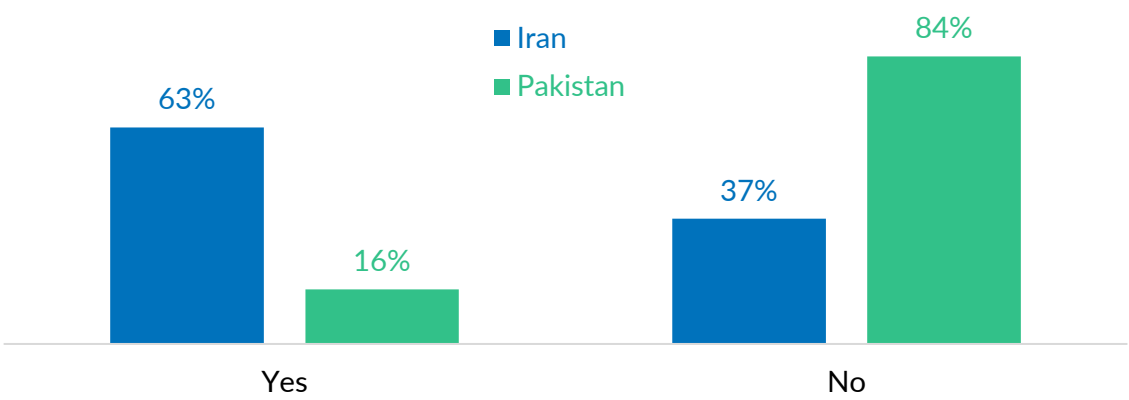


Chart # 8: Have you or your family experienced feelings of stress that affected your day-to-day life

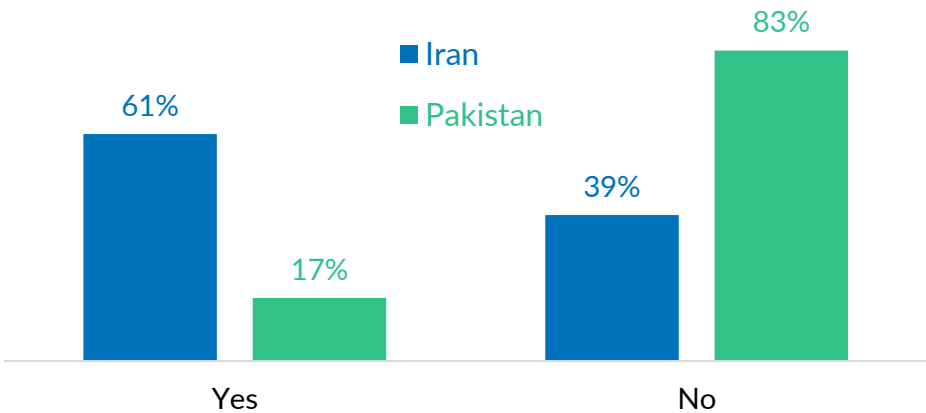
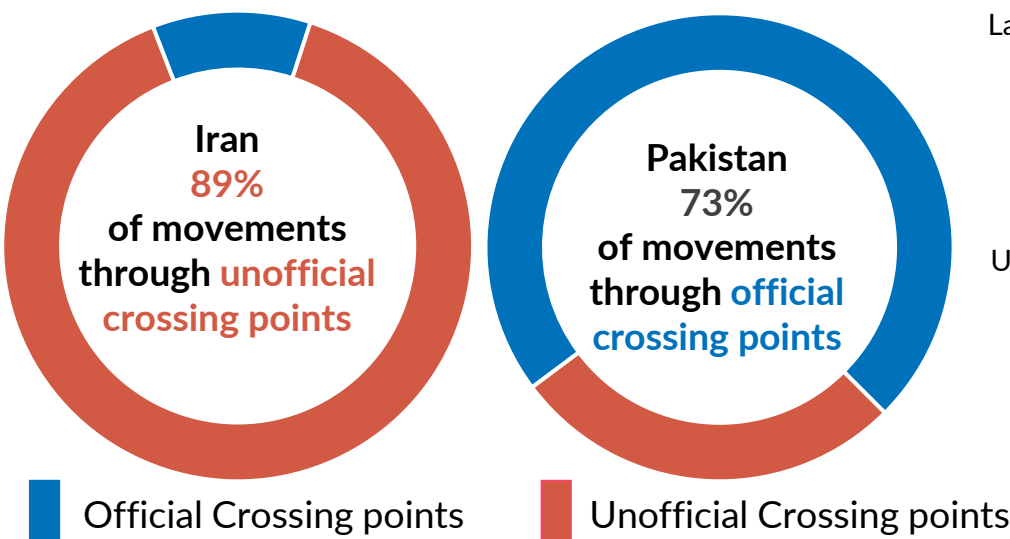
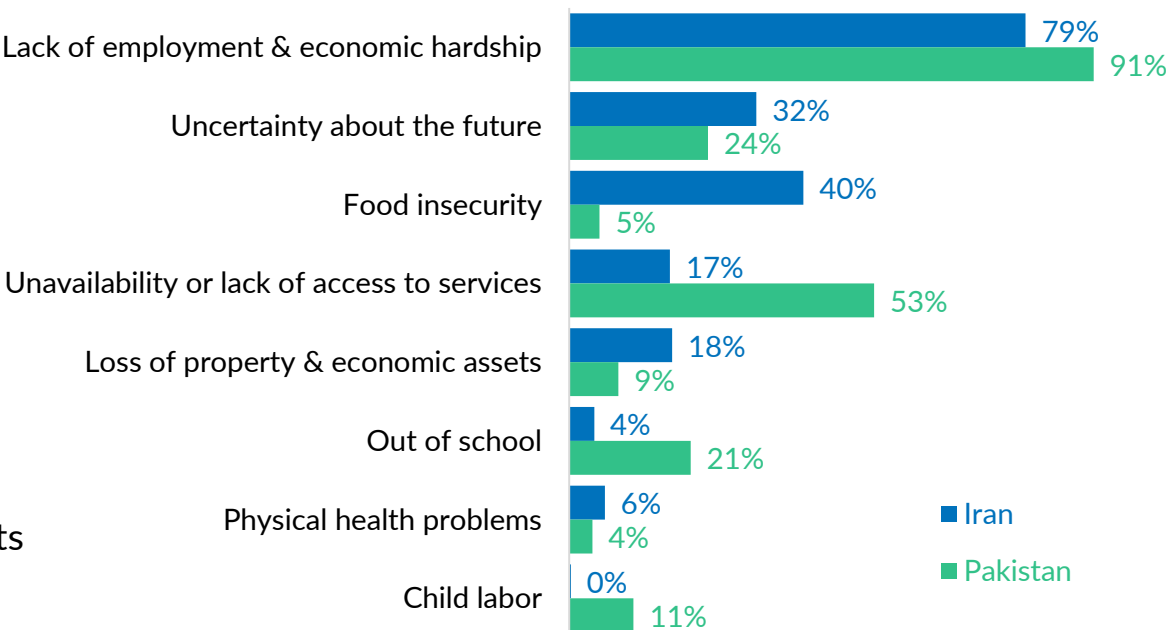


Chart # 9: Type of movement



Chart# 10: Sources of stress



Inflow Monitoring Findings

1 January – 30 April 2026

Chart # 11: Reasons of return from Pakistan

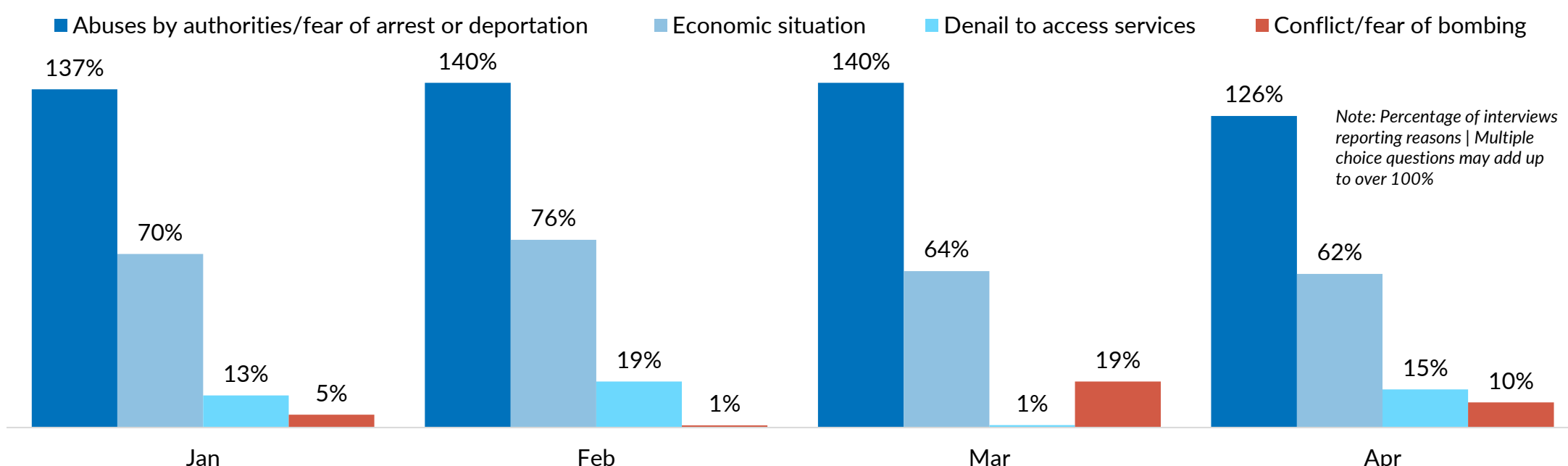


Chart # 12: Reasons of return from Iran

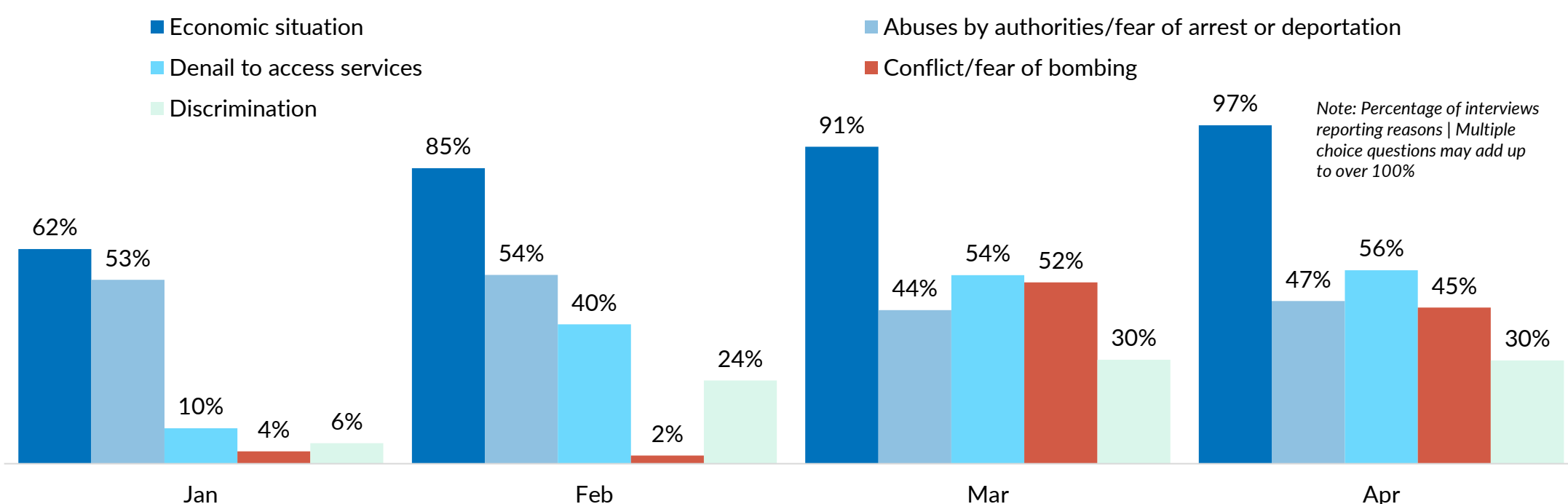


Chart # 13: Occupational skills (HoHs) - Returnees from Iran

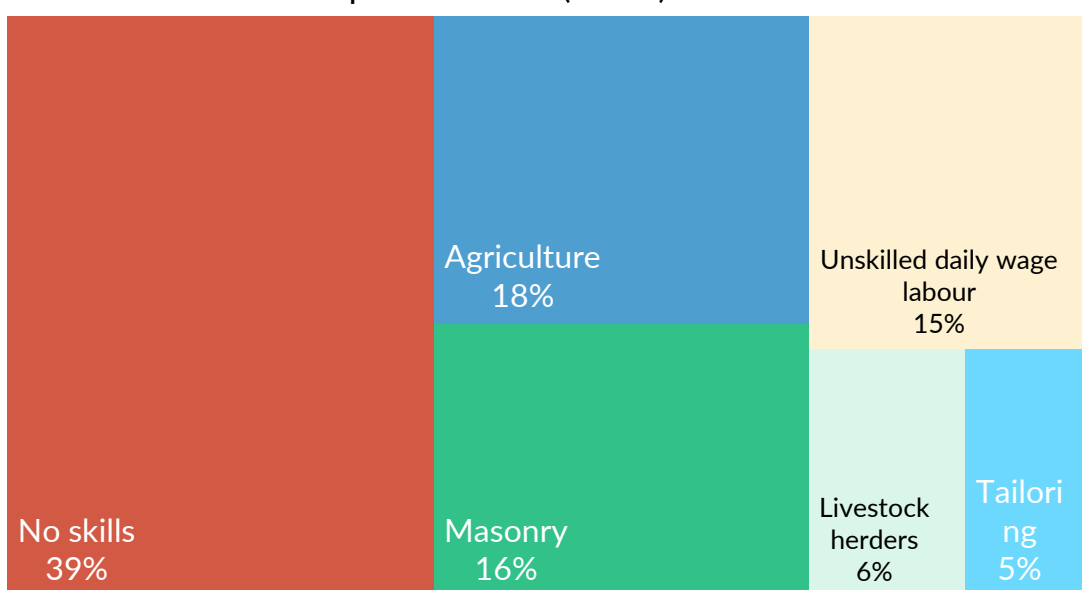


Chart # 14: Occupational skills (HoHs) - Returnees from Pakistan

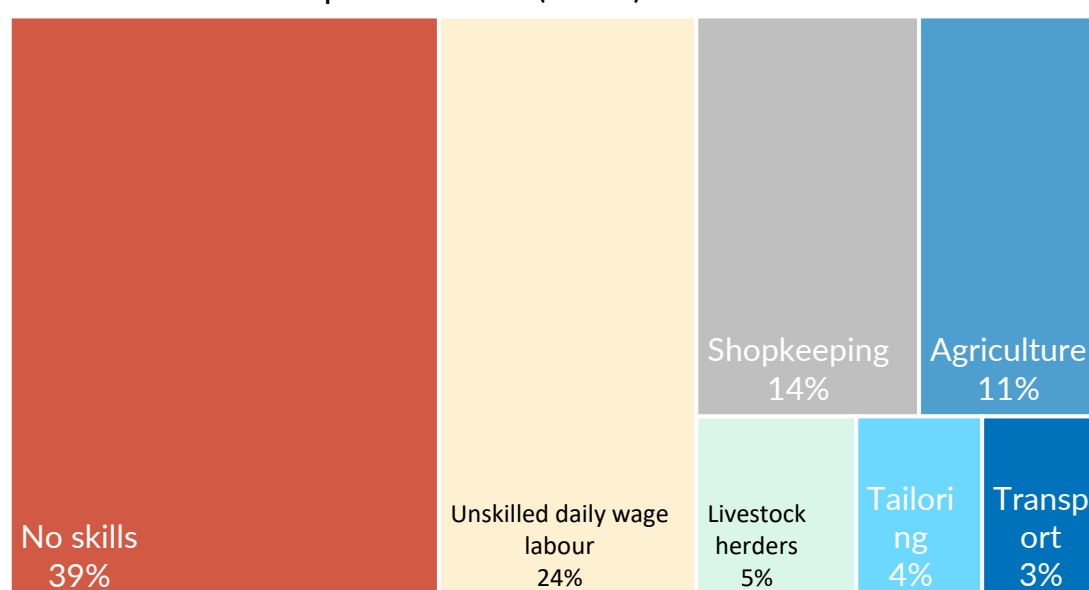


Chart # 15: Education levels (HoH) returnees from Iran and Pakistan

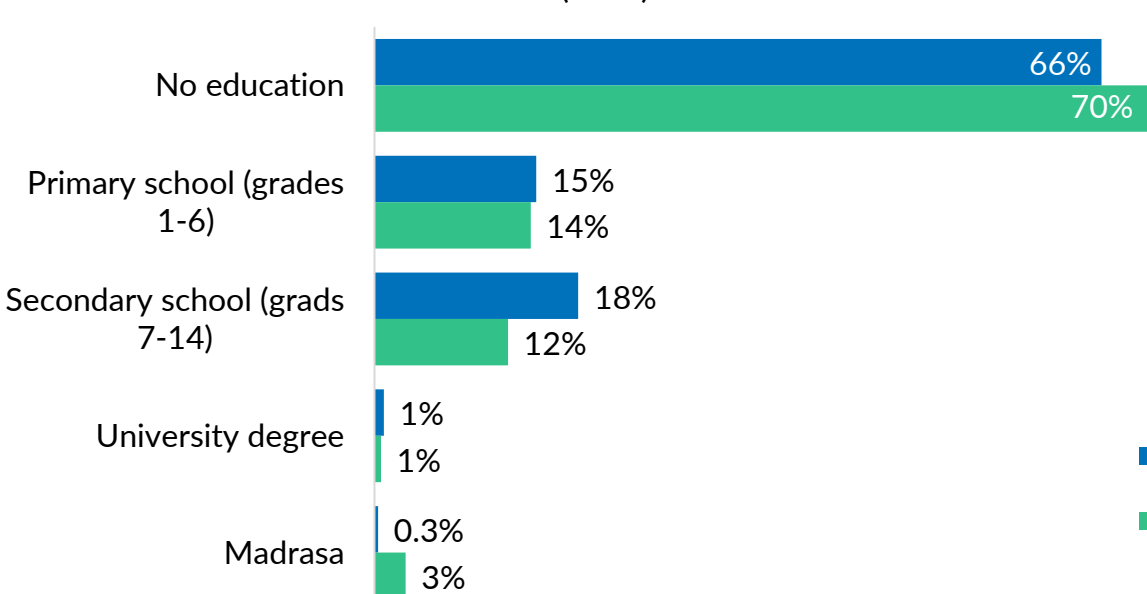


Chart # 16: Documentation stats of respondents

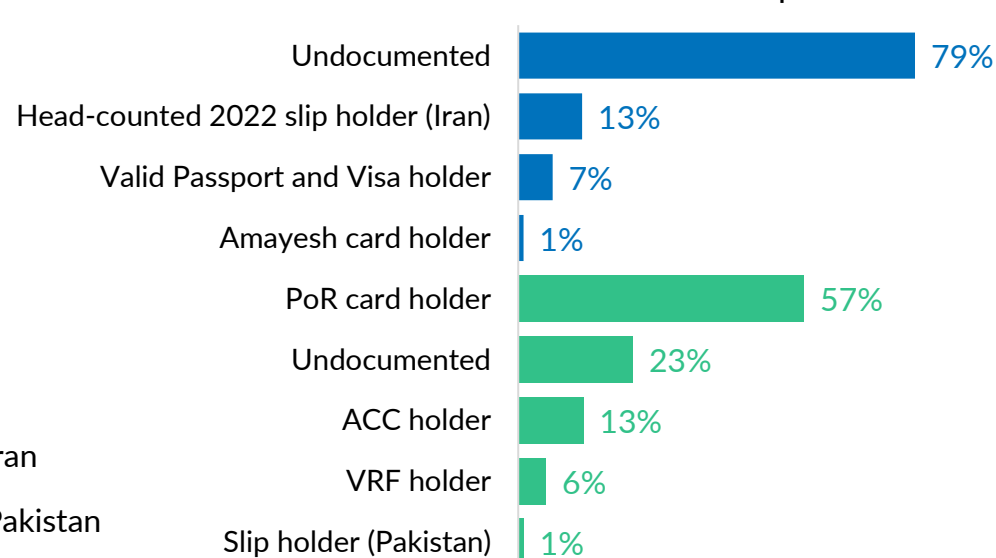


Chart # 17:

Return/Deportations from Pakistan
(1 Jan– 30 Apr 2025 vs 2026)

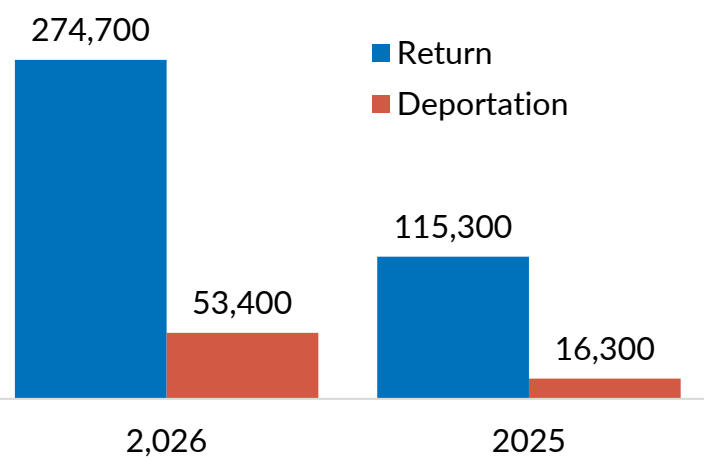


Chart # 18: Overall Return/Deportation form Pakistan - 1 Jan - 30 Apr 2026

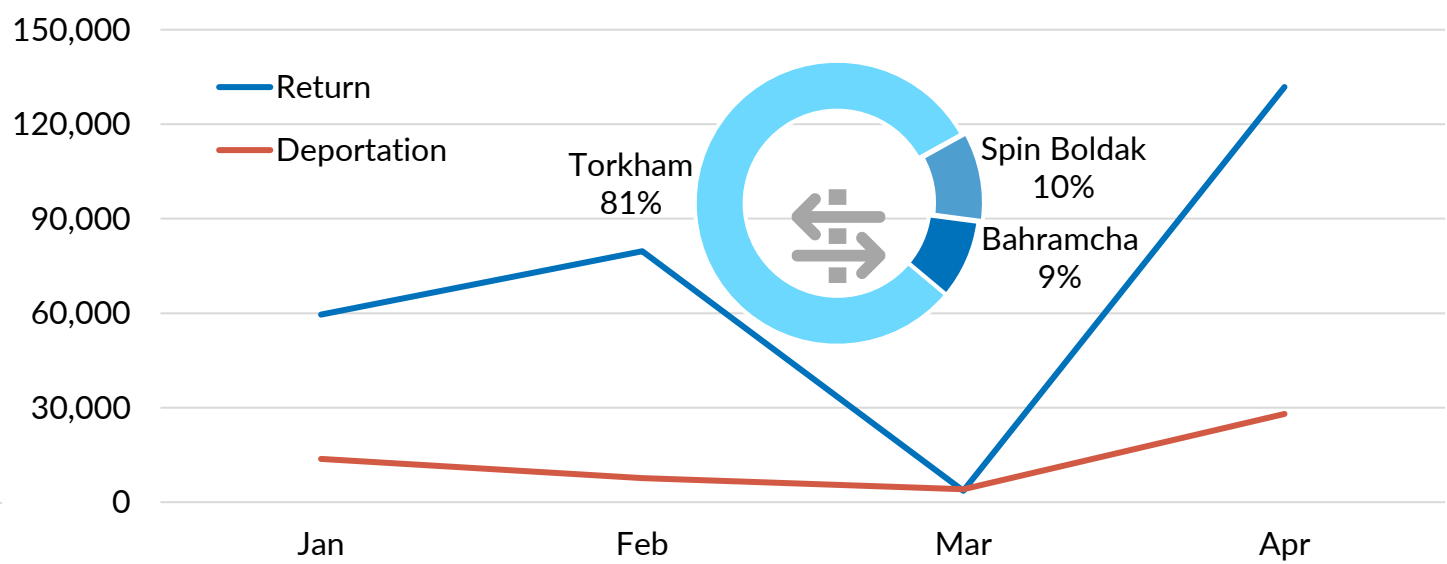


Chart # 19:

Return/Deportations from Iran
(1 Jan– 30 Apr 2025 vs 2026)

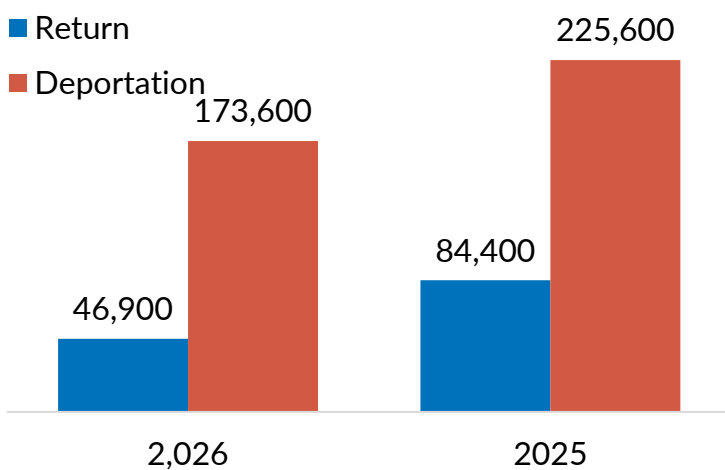
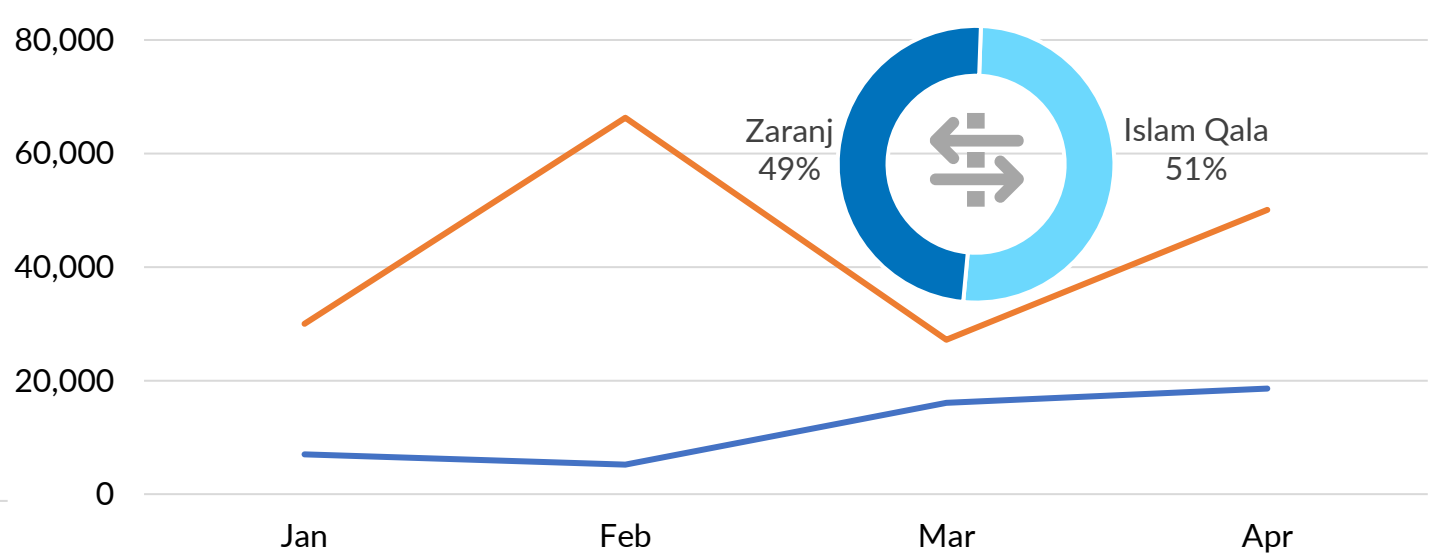


Chart # 20: Overall Return/Deportation form Iran - 1 Jan - 30 Apr 2026



UNHCR would like to thank first and foremost the thousands of returnees who agreed to take the survey and contributed invaluable information.

Across the Asia and the Pacific region, UNHCR has been forced to reprioritize programmes due to constrained humanitarian funding. Many refugees, stateless people, and other forcibly displaced populations face reduced access to critical assistance, with women and children among the most affected.

UNHCR is deeply grateful to the following donors who have stepped forward with earmarked contributions and those providing flexible funding to Afghanistan, enabling life-saving assistance and protection to reach those most in need. These contributions are vital to sustaining operations and supporting the most vulnerable:

Austria | Canada | European Union | Germany | Islamic Development Bank | Italy | Japan | Republic of Korea | Saudi Fund for Development | Switzerland | Afghanistan Humanitarian Fund | Afghanistan Humanitarian Trust Fund | Central Emergency Response Fund | Special Trust Fund for Afghanistan

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UNHCR AFGHANISTAN

Q1 2026 Border Monitoring
and Return Response Report

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